A Marathi Summer

WITH COMPELLING NARRATIVES AND WELL-ROUNDED CHARACTERS, MARATHI FILMS ARE GATHERING CRITICAL AND COMMERCIAL ACCLAIM, DESPITE HAVING NEITHER THE MONEY NOR THE STAR POWER OF BOLLYWOOD

By Suhani Singh



LONG LIVE THE KING Riteish Deshmukh-starrer *Raja Shivaji* tells the story of the Maratha ruler in the early days of his empire



IN FOREIGN COUNTRY *Toh Ti Ani Fuji* tells the story of a broken-up couple reuniting years later

TWO ESTRANGED SISTERS COME TOGETHER TO LOOK AFTER THEIR CANCER-STRICKEN MOTHER, who has a dark secret. A couple who split on a turbulent note meet unexpectedly in Tokyo where they confront why things fell apart. A father and son come to terms with the fact that the wife and mother who left them is now a man. A famous Maratha ruler battles Muslim adversaries and familiarises his people with the concept of *swarajya* (self-rule).

These are the themes of four Marathi films—*Tighee* (Three Women), *Toh Ti Anu Fuji* (He, Her and Fuji), *Baapya* and *Raja Shivaji*—released in just the first five months of 2026 and already creating waves. Bollywood may be the big daddy of the region, commanding giant budgets and bankable national stars, but Marathi cinema is slowly and steadily making a mark on the back of compelling narratives and well-rounded characters.

The appeal of Marathi cinema, says Jeejivisha Kale, who made her directorial debut with *Tighee*, has always been its "progressive" streak. "That's why I felt so comfortable coming up with a story like *Tighee*." Addressing issues like child sexual abuse, workplace harassment and the passage of trauma, *Tighee* is an assured debut, with measured performances by Bharti Achrekar as the matriarch and Nehha Pendse and Sonalee Kulkarni as her daughters. At the same time, it is more than just a mother-daughters relationship drama, capturing the everyday experiences of women. "You are aware of being looked at differently. There is a policing of how you say things in front of people you have grown up with," says Kale. "There is always a hushed tone when people know things have happened within families but choose not to believe it."

Much like *Tighee*, the lived reality of modern relationships also inspired writer-director Mohit Takalkar's *Toh Ti Ani Fuji*, in which actors Lalit Prabhakar and Mrinmayee Godbole play an estranged couple reflecting on their relationship years later. "Relationships today are negotiating ambition, careers, migration, loneliness,